The First Global Web

How trade, faith, and innovation connected Europe, Africa, and Asia.

Gemini Notebook

By the 1400s, a complex trade network linked three continents.

The globalized world is not a modern invention. Centuries before the modern era, the Old World was fundamentally connected.

The Middle East served as the ultimate crossroads, where ships from China and India brought spices, silks, and gems to Red Sea ports before they were taken overland.

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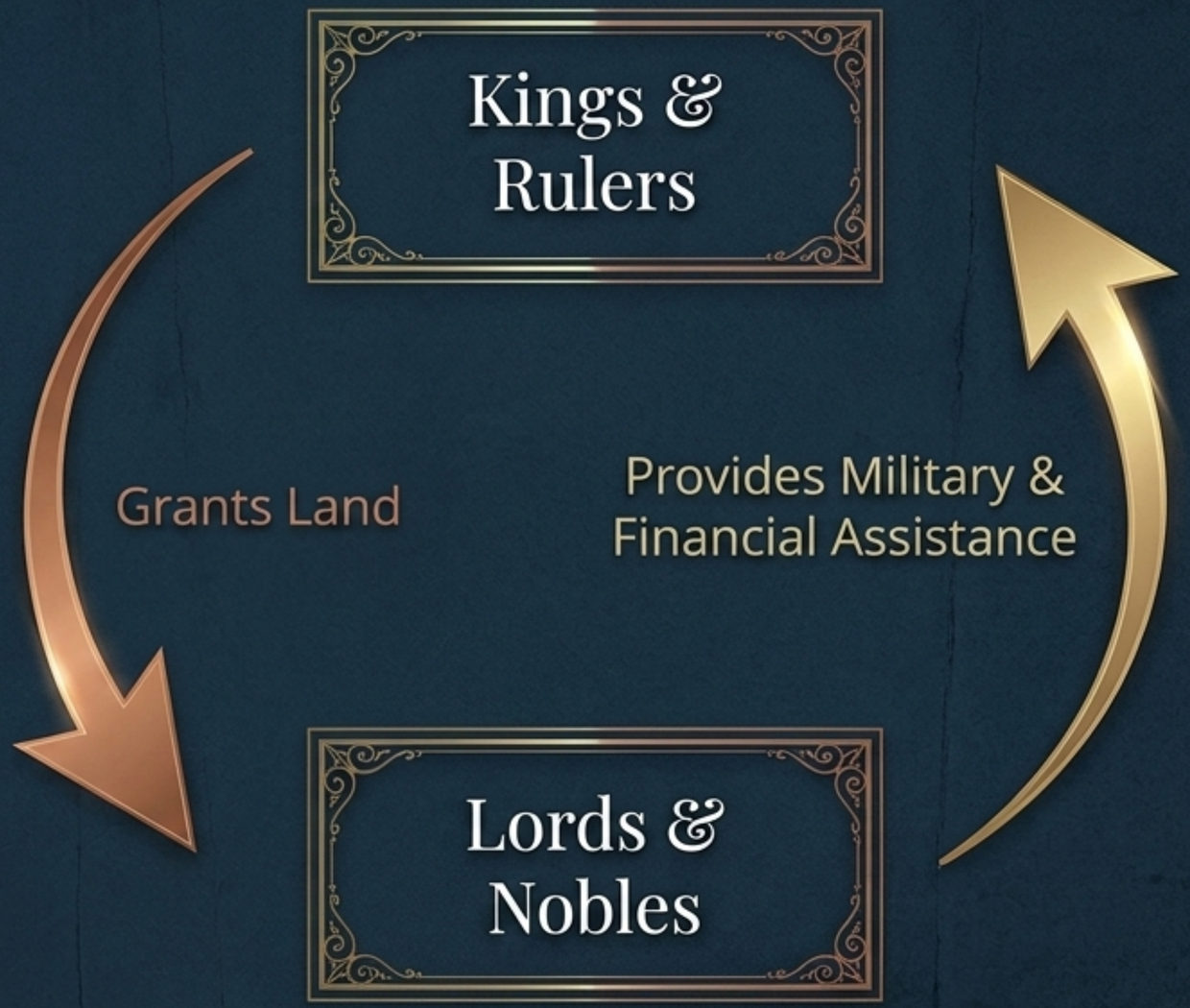
Western Europe fractures into the Feudal system.

When the western Roman empire fell to invaders in A.D. 476, Europe fragmented into small states, ushering in the thousand-year-long Middle Ages.

By the 800s, a strict system of reciprocal exchange called feudalism became the primary economic and political engine.



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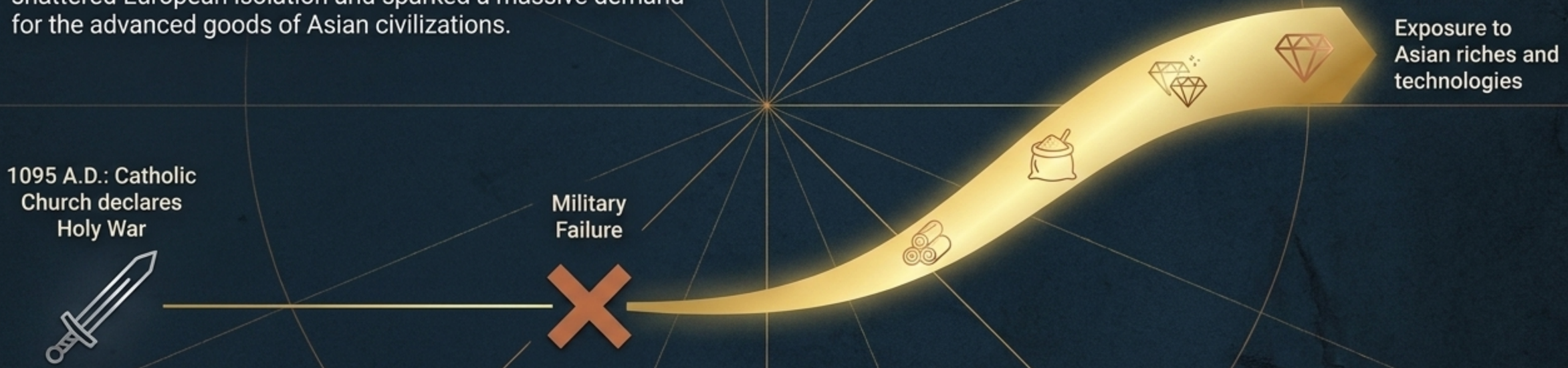
The Crusades failed militarily, but succeeded economically.

The Catholic Church played a massive role in medieval Europe. In 1095, Pope Urban II declared a crusade to win control of the Holy Land from Muslims.

While these holy wars failed their primary objective, they shattered European isolation and sparked a massive demand for the advanced goods of Asian civilizations.



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Islam spreads through a dual engine of conquest and commerce.

Founded in the Arabian Peninsula in the A.D. 600s by the prophet Muhammad, Islam rose rapidly. It spread simultaneously through the military conquests of Arab armies and the expansive trade routes of Muslim merchants, resulting in millions of conversions across multiple continents.

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Middle Eastern scholars trade knowledge and upgrade global shipping.

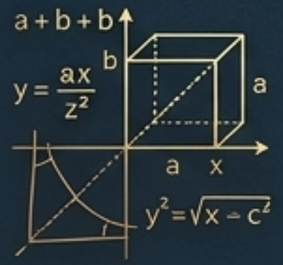
The Middle East contributed far more than trade routes. Scholars advanced global mathematics (algebra), medicine, and astronomy.

Crucially, they introduced large triangular sails that fundamentally changed global navigation by allowing ships to sail closer to the wind.

Knowledge

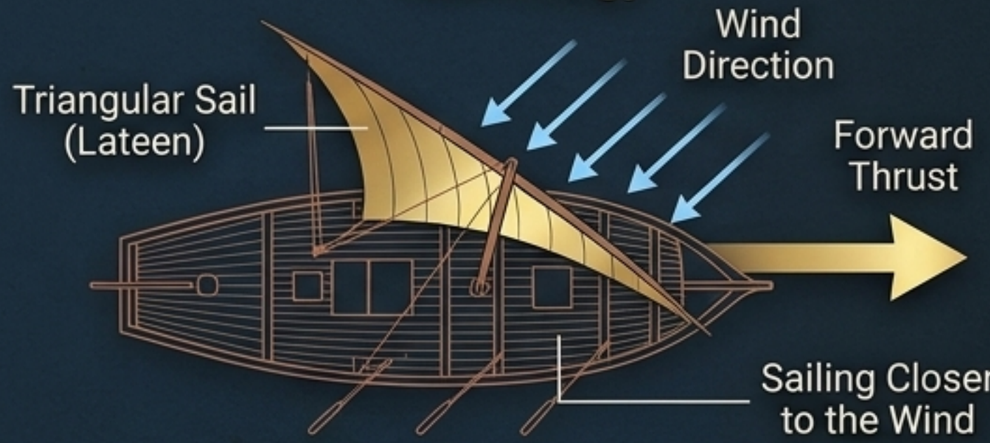
Astronomy

Medicine



Algebra

Technology



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Africa develops two immensely wealthy trade ecosystems.

By 1000 A.D., Africa was a major player in the global web, anchored by two distinct geographic resource engines: the eastern coastal hubs that linked to Asia, and the western desert empires that linked to the Middle East.

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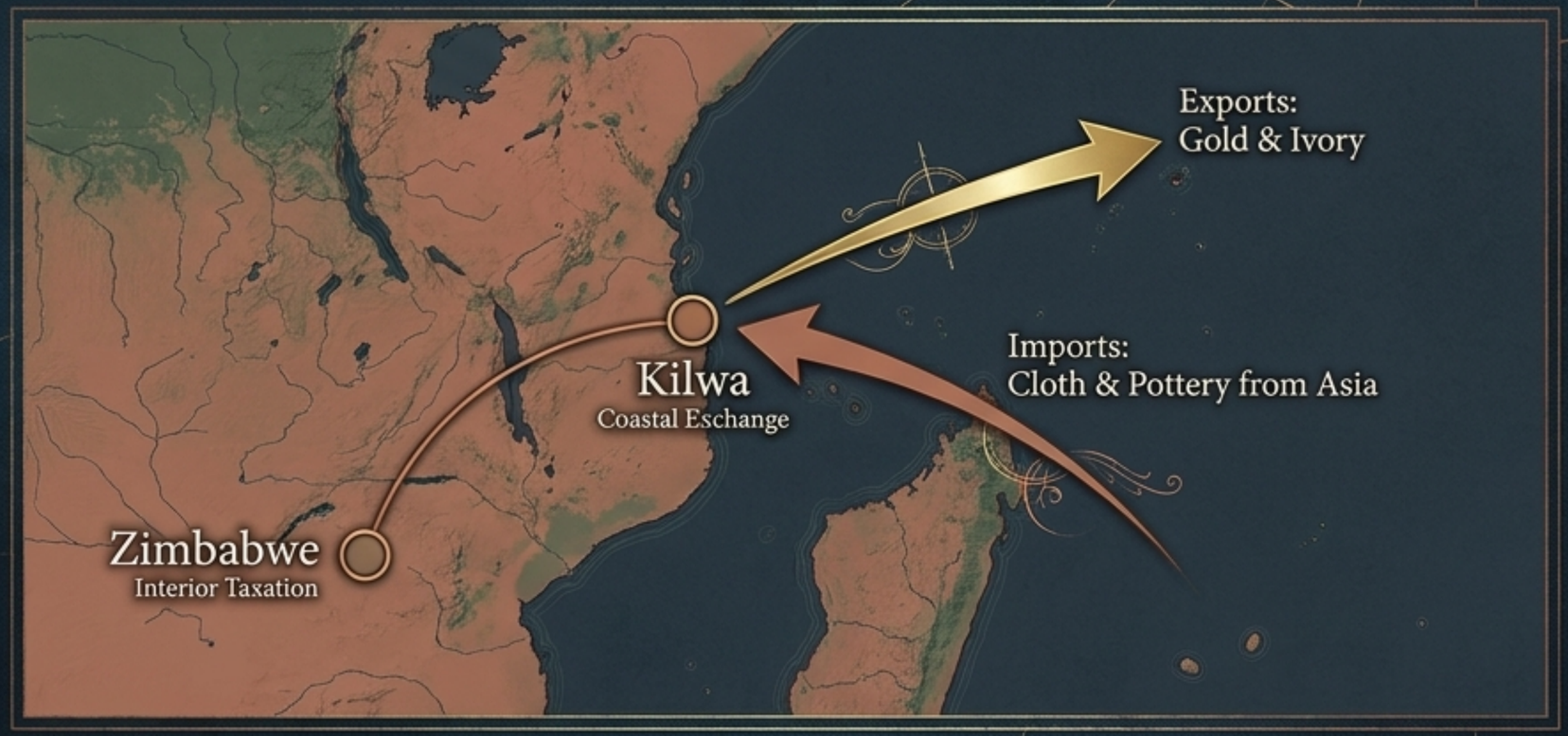
Location dictates power in the East African Indian Ocean network.

Inland, Zimbabwe became highly powerful by taxing the goods moving along routes from the interior to the coast. On the shoreline, cities like Kilwa prospered by acting as the final exchange points for Asian goods. (A lucrative slave trade to Asia also developed across these Indian Ocean routes).



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Successive empires dominate the Saharan caravans.

Desert nomads crossed the Sahara with camel caravans, directly linking the Middle East to West Africa. Three successive kingdoms grew immensely wealthy by controlling the crucial space between northern salt mines and southern gold fields.

Ghana	Mali	Songhai
First major West African trade center.	Absorbed Ghana in the 1200s.	Captured Timbuktu in 1468.
Strategic location between salt mines and gold fields.	Retained control of the salt and gold trades.	Flourished from salt, gold, and slave trades.
Weakened by war and shifting trade routes.	Declined in the 1400s under a series of weak rulers.	Solidified the final pre-modern Saharan network.

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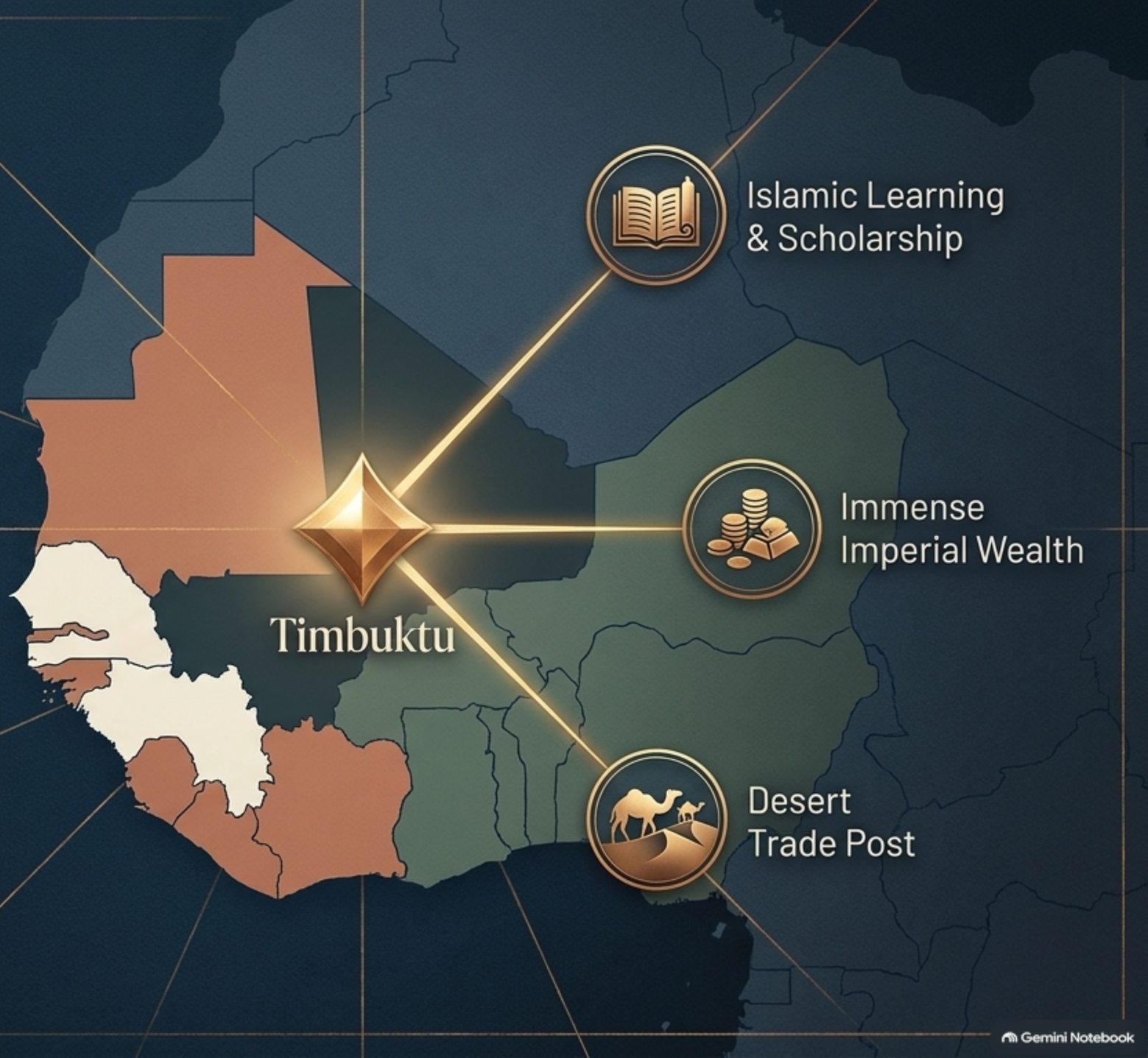
Mansa Musa sparks a golden age of scholarship in Mali.

In the 1200s, Mali's ruler Mansa Musa transformed his empire. As a devout Muslim, he elevated the great city of Timbuktu from a mere trade post into a globally renowned center of Islamic learning, drawing scholars from across the interconnected world.



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China builds a unified economic engine.

While Europe spent centuries fractured, China was unified early (221 B.C.) and expanded rapidly. This massive internal cohesion, linked by advanced infrastructure, provided the industrial base required to export goods across the globe.

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Chinese innovation breaks the coastline barrier.

Expanding trade required pushing past physical boundaries. Advances in navigation—specifically the science of locating and plotting courses via the magnetic compass—allowed sailors to finally lose sight of land and confidently return home.

Line of Sight Navigation

Scientific Navigation

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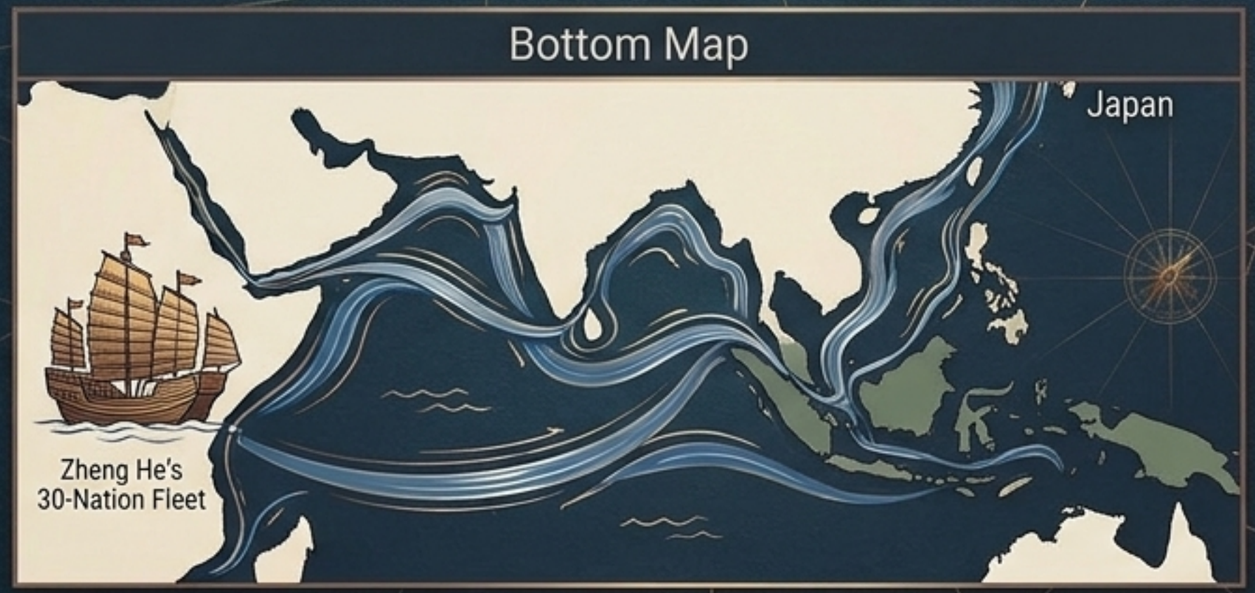
Two paths to the West: The Silk Road and Zheng He's fleet.

Chinese dominance flowed outward via two massive arteries. Overland, merchants carried goods across the 5,000-mile series of routes known as the Silk Road.

By sea in the 1300s, explorer Zheng He utilized fleets of giant ships to visit 30 nations across Asia and Africa.



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